

NOC & Service-Desk Operating Standard

How a well-run NOC and service desk operates — a general standard you're free to adopt or adapt.

This is the operating discipline good NOC teams run on, stripped to what applies anywhere. Tool names, windows and contacts are yours to fill in; the principles hold regardless of stack.

1. How we work

- **Own what you touch.** A ticket assigned to you is yours until it's resolved or formally handed over.
- **Acknowledge fast** — even if the answer is only “received, working on it.” “No change yet” beats silence.
- **Write everything down.** Your notes are how the next engineer, the relief person and the auditor see your work.
- **Ask early.** Nobody is ever in trouble for consulting a lead; people get into trouble improvising on production.
- **When quality and speed conflict, quality wins.**

2. The shape of every day

- Start by reading: the previous handover, your queue, and the alerts on your systems.
- Prioritise by breach risk and impact — not by what's loudest.
- Work every ticket through the ticket workflow, small tickets included.
- Update the requester at agreed intervals.
- End by writing the handover that lets the next person start without calling you. A shift isn't over until its handover is written.

3. Ticket discipline

- State the objective in one line when you pick a ticket up.
- Record what you checked, found, did and verified — a stranger should be able to continue from your notes.
- Log real time worked; the team's sizing rests on honest numbers.
- Three repeats of the same issue is one problem record, not three closures.
- Escalate as a package: attempts, logs, timeline.

4. Security awareness

- Verify identity before any account, access or data action — every time, whoever is asking.
- Least privilege always; credentials are personal, never shared, never in tickets.
- Anything temporary (elevated rights, firewall openings, debug logging, test accounts) gets an expiry and is reverted before log off.
- Report phishing and impersonation; never test them.
- Security alerts are never closed as noise without approved, documented tuning.

5. Data protection

- Work under the data-protection law that applies to the client (e.g. GDPR, DPDP, state privacy laws) and their own policies.
- Purpose limitation: view only the personal data the task needs.
- Client data never touches personal devices, email, cloud or chat apps; it leaves client systems only by approved, encrypted channels.
- Mask names, identifiers and contacts in test systems, screenshots and knowledge articles.
- A breach or suspected breach goes to the manager immediately — the reporting clock starts at discovery. Health and payment data raise the bar.

6. The bands

- **Band A** — hands-on first line: service-desk L1 and NOC analysts.
- **Band B** — second line and shift leadership: desk L2 and the NOC shift lead.
- **Band C** — senior tower specialists: server, cloud, network, and relief/coverage.
- **Band D** — technical leadership across towers.
- **Service Delivery Manager** — owns governance, reporting and the client relationship. Progression is by demonstrated competency, reviewed regularly.

7. Escalation

Escalate early, with evidence. The common triggers and who they go to:

- P1/P2 at breach risk → on-shift lead + on-call tower engineer, immediately, by call.
- Credential or access failure → on-shift lead, before retrying.
- Suspected security incident or data breach → manager + client security contact, immediately, call then written.
- Change going wrong mid-window → on-call tower + manager, before improvising.
- Unhappy client or VIP → manager, within the hour.
- Unclear objective after reading everything → your lead, before acting.

This is the standard our people are trained to. Share it, adapt it, or use it to pressure-test your own desk — it's useful either way. If it would help to talk through how it maps to your environment, I'm glad to.

— Salil Gautam, DedicatusIT · 15 years in MSP & NOC operations (ex-ConnectWise)